fledged. The cuckoo is usually much larger, in some cases grotesquely larger, than its ‘parent’. I am looking at a photograph of an adult dunnock, so small in comparison to its monstrous foster child that it has to perch on its back in order to feed it. Here we feel less sympathy for the host. We marvel at its stupidity, its gullibility. Surely any fool should be able to see that there is something wrong with a child like that.

I think that cuckoo nestlings must be doing rather more than just ‘fooling’ their hosts, more than just pretending to be something that they aren’t. They seem to act on the host’s nervous system in rather the same way as an addictive drug. This is not so hard to sympathize with, even for those with no experience of addictive drugs. A man can be aroused, even to erection, by a printed photograph of a woman’s body. He is not ‘fooled’ into thinking that the pattern of printing ink really is a woman. He knows that he is only looking at ink on paper, yet his nervous system responds to it in the same kind of way as it might respond to a real woman. We may find the attractions of a particular member of the opposite sex irresistible, even though the better judgment of our better self tells us that a liaison with that person is not in anyone’s long-term interests. The same can be true of the irresistible attractions of unhealthy food. The dunnock probably has no conscious awareness of its long-term best interests, so it is even easier to understand that its nervous system might find certain kinds of stimulation irresistible.

So enticing is the red gape of a cuckoo nestling that it is not uncommon for ornithologists to see a bird dropping food into the mouth of a baby cuckoo sitting in some other bird’s nest! A bird may be flying home, carrying food for its own young. Suddenly, out of the corner of its eye, it sees the red super-gape of a young cuckoo, in the nest of a bird of some quite different species. It is diverted to the alien nest where it drops into the cuckoo’s mouth the food that had been destined for its own young. The ‘irresistibility theory’ fits with the views of early German ornithologists who referred to foster parents as behaving like ‘addicts’ and to the cuckoo nestling as their ‘vice’. It is only fair to add that this kind of language finds less favour with some modern experimenters. But there’s no doubt that if we do assume that the cuckoo’s gape is a powerful drug-like superstimulus, it becomes very much easier to explain what is going on. It becomes easier to sympathize with the behaviour of the diminutive parent standing on the back of its monstrous child. It is not being stupid. ‘Fooled’ is the wrong word to use. Its